中国人的名字和称呼

姓名·小名·亲戚怎么叫

Chinese Names and Family Terms

Surnames, given names, pet names and what to call your relatives

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 每个人都有名字。可是中国人的名字和西方人的名字有很多不同的地方。中国的亲戚[†]称呼[‡]也特别复杂，英语里的一个“uncle”，在汉语里可能是五六个不同的词。今天我们就来聊聊中国人的姓名和称呼。

姓在前，名在后

2 中国人的名字有两个部分：前面是姓，后面是名。比如“王小明[§]”，“王”是姓，“小明[¶]”是名。这和英语的顺序正好相反。所以，外国人第一次看到中国名字的时候，常常不知道哪个是姓，哪个是名。

3 中国人口很多，可是常用的姓并不多。

† 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
‡ 称呼 *chēnghu* form of address
§ 王小明 *Wáng Xiǎomíng* Wang Xiaoming (a typical name)
¶ 小明 *Xiǎomíng* Xiaoming (given name)

Everyone has a name. But Chinese names differ from Western names in many ways. Chinese terms for relatives are also very complicated: the single English word "uncle" may be five or six different words in Chinese. Today, let's talk about Chinese names and forms of address. 1

Surname First, Given Name Second

A Chinese name has two parts: the surname comes first and the given name after it. In "Wang Xiaoming", for example, "Wang" is the surname and "Xiaoming" the given name. This is exactly the opposite of the English order. So when foreigners first see a Chinese name, they often can't tell which part is the surname and which is the given name. 2

China has a huge population, but the number of common surnames is not large. 3

3 王、李[†]、张是最常见的三个姓，每个姓都有差不多一亿人。大部分姓只有一个字，也有少数是两个字的，比如欧阳[‡]、司马[§]。因为同[¶]姓的人太多了，同名同姓[*]的情况也很常见。据说，全国叫“张伟[#]”的人就有几十万。在学校里，如果一个班有两个同学名字一样，老师只好叫他们“大张伟”和“小张伟”。

名字的意思

4 名可以是一个字，也可以是两个字。二三十年前，一个字的名很流行；现在大部分父母更喜欢给孩子起两个字的名，因为这样不容易和别人重名。起名字是一件大事。父母会认真地选字，希望名字有好的意思。

† 李 *Lǐ* Li (surname)
‡ 欧阳 *Ōuyáng* Ouyang (surname)
§ 司马 *Sīmǎ* Sima (surname)
¶ 同 *tóng* same
* 同名同姓 *tóngmíng tóngxìng* having exactly the same name
张伟 *Zhāng Wěi* Zhang Wei (a very common name)

Wang, Li and Zhang are the three most common surnames, and each is shared by roughly a hundred million people. Most surnames have a single character, but a few have two, such as Ouyang and Sima. With so many people sharing a surname, it is also common for people to have exactly the same full name. It is said that several hundred thousand people in China are called "Zhang Wei". At school, if two classmates have the same name, the teacher has no choice but to call them "Big Zhang Wei" and "Little Zhang Wei". 3

What Names Mean

A given name can have one character or two. Twenty or thirty years ago one-character given names were very popular; now most parents prefer two characters, because that makes it less likely the child will share a name with someone else. Choosing a name is a big deal. Parents choose the characters carefully, hoping the name will have a good meaning. 4

5 男孩的名字里常常有“伟”、“强”、“勇”这样的字，希望孩子以后又强又有勇气。女孩的名字里常常有“美”、“丽”、“静”、“雪”这样的字，意思是美丽、安静、干净。有的名字还和出生的时间有关[1]，比如冬天出生的孩子可能叫“冬冬[2]”，早上出生的可能叫“晨[3]”。很多家庭起名字的时候会一起商量，爷爷奶奶的意见常常很重要；有的人还会花钱请专门的人帮孩子起名。

6 起名字的时候，还要注意声音。汉语里发音一样的字很多，一个很好的名字，读出来可能像一句好笑[4]的话。网上有一个有名的笑话：一个姓杜[5]的人叫“杜子腾[6]”，字的意思都没有问题，可是听起来就像“肚子疼”。所以，很多父母选好名字以后，会大声读几遍，看看有没有[7]问题。

1 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
2 冬冬 *Dōngdōng* Dongdong (name; 冬 = winter)
3 晨 *Chén* Chen (name; “morning”)
4 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny
5 杜 *Dù* Du (surname)
6 杜子腾 *Dù Zǐténg* Du Ziteng (joke name)
7 有没有 *yǒuméiyǒu* whether there is

Boys' names often contain characters like 伟 (great), 强 (strong) and 勇 (brave), expressing the hope that the child will grow up strong and courageous. Girls' names often contain characters like 美 (beautiful), 丽 (lovely), 静 (calm) and 雪 (snow), standing for beauty, calm and purity. Some names are linked to the time of birth: a child born in winter might be called Dongdong (冬 means winter), and one born in the morning might be named Chen ("morning"). Many families discuss the choice together, and the grandparents' opinion often carries great weight; some people even pay a professional to name their child. 5

When choosing a name, you also have to pay attention to how it sounds. Chinese has many characters that sound alike, so a perfectly good name, read aloud, may sound like something funny. There is a well-known joke online about a man surnamed Du who is called Du Ziteng: the characters themselves are fine, but the name sounds just like "stomachache" (肚子疼). So after choosing a name, many parents read it aloud a few times to check for problems. 6

7 在传统的大家庭里，还有一种特别的习惯，叫“字辈[1]”。同[2]一代的兄弟，包括堂兄弟[3]，名字里都有同一个字。比如，李建国[4]和李建华[5]是兄弟，他们的名字里都有“建”字。每一代用哪个字，早就写在家谱[6]里了，有时候是很长的一首诗，一个字代表一代人。看名字，就能知道一个人在家族[7]里是哪一代。现在，城市里用字辈的家庭已经不多了，可是在一些农村，这个习惯还保留着。

结婚以后的姓

8 在很多西方国家，女人结婚以后常常改用丈夫的姓。可是在中国，女人结婚以后不改姓。王丽[8]嫁[9]给了李[10]先生，她还是叫王丽，身份证上的名字也不变。

1 字辈 *zìbèi* generation character in names
2 同 *tóng* same
3 堂兄弟 *tángxiōngdì* male cousins on the father's side
4 李建国 *Lǐ Jiànguó* Li Jianguo (a name)
5 李建华 *Lǐ Jiànhuá* Li Jianhua (a name)
6 家谱 *jiāpǔ* family genealogy
7 家族 *jiāzú* clan
8 王丽 *Wáng Lì* Wang Li (a name)
9 嫁 *jià* to marry (a husband)
10 李 *Lǐ* Li (surname)

In large traditional families there was another special custom, called the "generation name". Brothers of the same generation, including cousins on the father's side, all share one character in their names. For example, Li Jianguo and Li Jianhua are brothers, and both their names contain 建. Which character each generation uses was fixed long ago in the family genealogy, sometimes as a long poem in which each character stands for one generation. From someone's name, you could tell which generation of the clan they belonged to. Today few urban families still use generation names, but in some villages the custom survives. 7

Surnames after Marriage

In many Western countries, women often take their husband's surname when they marry. In China, however, women do not change their surname after marriage. When Wang Li marries Mr Li, she is still called Wang Li, and the name on her ID card does not change. 8

不过，在一些场合，别人可能会叫她“李[1]太太”。

孩子一般跟爸爸姓，但是法律也允许[2]孩子跟妈妈姓。现在，有的家庭有两个孩子，一个跟爸爸姓，一个跟妈妈姓，这样两边的老人都高兴。也有一些父母把两个人的姓都放进孩子的名字里：比如爸爸姓张，妈妈姓林[3]，孩子可能叫“张林悦[4]”。

小名和英文名

除了正式的名字，很多中国孩子还有一个小名[5]。小名一般很简单、很可爱，比如“豆豆[6]”、“乐乐[7]”、“小胖[8]”。在家里，爸爸妈妈一直用小名叫孩子，有时候孩子长大了还这样叫。

1 李 *Lǐ* Li (surname)
2 允许 *yǔnxǔ* to allow
3 林 *Lín* Lin (surname)
4 张林悦 *Zhāng Línyuè* Zhang Linyue (a name)
5 小名 *xiǎomíng* childhood pet name
6 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (“little bean”)
7 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele (“happy”)
8 小胖 *Xiǎopàng* Xiaopang (“little chubby”)

On some occasions, though, people may still call her "Mrs Li". 8

Children usually take their father's surname, but the law also allows them to take their mother's. Nowadays some families with two children give one the father's surname and the other the mother's, so that both sets of grandparents are happy. Some parents put both surnames into the child's name: if the father is a Zhang and the mother a Lin, the child might be called Zhang Linyue. 9

Pet Names and English Names

Besides their official name, many Chinese children also have a pet name. Pet names are usually simple and cute, such as Doudou ("little bean"), Lele ("happy") or Xiaopang ("chubby"). At home, parents always use the pet name, sometimes even after the child has grown up. 10

10 很多人不喜欢让同学或者同事知道自己的小名[1]，因为觉得有点儿不好意思。反过来[2]，如果妈妈突然用全名叫你，比如“王小明[3]！”，那你就知道：她生气了。

11 在工作单位里，人们常常在姓前面加“小”或者“老”。年轻的同事叫“小王”、“小李[4]”，年纪大一点儿的叫“老张[5]”、“老陈[6]”。这里的“老”不是不礼貌[7]，反而有亲切和尊重[8]的意思。朋友之间常常只叫名，不叫姓，比如叫王小明“小明[9]”；关系很好的女孩子之间，还会把一个字说两遍，比如“丽丽[10]”。

12 现在，很多年轻人还有一个英文名，特别是在外国公司工作或者在国外学习的人。

1 小名 *xiǎomíng* childhood pet name
2 反过来 *fǎnguòlai* conversely
3 王小明 *Wáng Xiǎomíng* Wang Xiaoming (a typical name)
4 小李 *Xiǎo Lǐ* Little Li
5 老张 *Lǎo Zhāng* Old Zhang (older colleague)
6 老陈 *Lǎo Chén* Old Chen
7 礼貌 *lǐmào* polite, politeness
8 尊重 *zūnzhòng* respect
9 小明 *Xiǎomíng* Xiaoming (given name)
10 丽丽 *Lìli* Lili (affectionate form)

Many people would rather their classmates or colleagues didn't find out their pet name, because it is a little embarrassing. Conversely, if your mother suddenly calls you by your full name — "Wang Xiaoming!" — you know she's angry. 10

At work, people often put 小 ("little") or 老 ("old") in front of a surname. Younger colleagues are called "Little Wang" or "Little Li", and slightly older ones "Old Zhang" or "Old Chen". Here 老 is not impolite at all; on the contrary, it sounds warm and respectful. Friends usually use only the given name, not the surname — Wang Xiaoming's friends call him "Xiaoming" — and girls who are close friends may even double a character, as in "Lili". 11

Today many young people also have an English name, especially those who work for foreign companies or study abroad. 12

12 有的英文名很普通，比如Tom、Lucy；有的却很特别，比如有人叫“Apple”或者“Lemon”，外国人听到了常常觉得很有意思。不过，回到家，大家还是用中文名字。

一个 uncle，五个词

13 学汉语的外国人常常说，最难的不是汉字，而是亲戚[1]的称呼[2]。在英语里，爸爸妈妈的兄弟都叫 uncle，可是汉语要分得很清楚。爸爸的哥哥叫“伯伯[3]”，爸爸的弟弟叫“叔叔”，妈妈的兄弟不管大小都叫“舅舅[4]”。还有，姑姑[5]的丈夫叫“姑父[6]”，姨妈[7]的丈夫叫“姨父[8]”。所以，一个英语单词 uncle，在汉语里至少有五个不同的说法[9]。

1 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
2 称呼 *chēnghu* form of address
3 伯伯 *bóbo* uncle (father's older brother)
4 舅舅 *jiùjiu* uncle (mother's brother)
5 姑姑 *gūgu* aunt (father's sister)
6 姑父 *gūfu* uncle (husband of father's sister)
7 姨妈 *yímā* aunt (mother's sister)
8 姨父 *yífu* uncle (husband of mother's sister)
9 说法 *shuōfǎ* way of saying

Some English names are quite ordinary, like Tom or Lucy; others are unusual 12
— some people are called “Apple” or “Lemon” — which foreigners often find amusing. At home, though, everyone goes back to their Chinese name.

One “Uncle”, Five Words

Foreigners learning Chinese often say that the hardest part is not the char- 13
acters but the terms for relatives. In English, the brothers of both your father and your mother are all “uncle”, but Chinese makes careful distinctions. Your father’s older brother is 伯伯, his younger brother is 叔叔, and your mother’s brothers, older or younger, are all 舅舅. Then the husband of your father’s sister is 姑父, and the husband of your mother’s sister is 姨父. So the one English word “uncle” has at least five different equivalents in Chinese.

14 女亲戚[1]也一样。爸爸的姐妹叫“姑姑[2]”，妈妈的姐妹叫“姨妈[3]”或者“阿姨”；伯伯[4]的妻子叫“伯母[5]”，叔叔的妻子叫“婶婶[6]”，舅舅[7]的妻子叫“舅妈[8]”。爷爷、奶奶是爸爸的父母；妈妈的父母叫“外公[9]”、“外婆[10]”，北方人也叫“姥爷[11]”、“姥姥[12]”。这里的“外”字也有历史原因：在古代，女儿结婚以后就成为丈夫家的人，所以妈妈那边的亲戚被看作[13]“外”家。

15 爸爸妈妈的兄弟姐妹的孩子，也就是英语里的cousin，在汉语里也要分清楚。

1 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
2 姑姑 *gūgu* aunt (father's sister)
3 姨妈 *yímā* aunt (mother's sister)
4 伯伯 *bóbo* uncle (father's older brother)
5 伯母 *bómǔ* aunt (wife of father's older brother)
6 婶婶 *shěnshen* aunt (wife of father's younger brother)
7 舅舅 *jiùjiu* uncle (mother's brother)
8 舅妈 *jiùmā* aunt (wife of mother's brother)
9 外公 *wàigōng* grandfather (mother's father)
10 外婆 *wàipó* grandmother (mother's mother)
11 姥爷 *lǎoye* grandfather (mother's father, northern)
12 姥姥 *lǎolao* grandmother (mother's mother, northern)
13 看作 *kànzuò* to regard as

It's the same for female relatives. Your father's sisters are 姑姑, your mother's sisters 姨妈 or 阿姨; the wife of 伯伯 is 伯母, the wife of 叔叔 is 婶婶, and the wife of 舅舅 is 舅妈. 爷爷 and 奶奶 are your father's parents; your mother's parents are 外公 and 外婆, or 姥爷 and 姥姥 in the north. The character 外 ("outside") here also has a historical reason: in old times a daughter became part of her husband's family when she married, so relatives on the mother's side were seen as the "outside" family. 14

The children of your parents' brothers and sisters — "cousins" in English — also have to be told apart in Chinese. 15

15 伯伯[1]和叔叔的孩子跟你同[2]姓，叫“堂[3]”兄弟姐妹，比如堂哥[4]、堂妹[5]；其他的都叫“表”，比如表姐[6]、表弟[7]。再加上[8]男女和年龄[9]大小，一个cousin就变成了八个不同的词。

16 为什么汉语的称呼[10]这么复杂呢？一个原因是，以前的中国家庭很大，几代人常常住在一起，每个人在家里的位置都很重要。一个称呼就能说明很多信息：是爸爸那边还是妈妈那边，是男的还是女的，比你大还是比你小。如果同一种亲戚[11]有好几个，还可以加上数字，比如“大舅[12]”、“二姨[13]”、“三叔[14]”。今天，很多年轻人没有兄弟姐妹，他们的孩子用到这些称呼的机会越来越少了。

1 伯伯 *bóbo* uncle (father's older brother)
2 同 *tóng* same
3 堂 *táng* paternal (cousin with the same surname)
4 堂哥 *tánggē* older male cousin (father's side)
5 堂妹 *tángmèi* younger female cousin (father's side)
6 表姐 *biǎojiě* older female cousin (other side)
7 表弟 *biǎodì* younger male cousin (other side)
8 加上 *jiāshàng* to add
9 年龄 *niánlíng* age
10 称呼 *chēnghu* form of address
11 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
12 大舅 *dàjiù* eldest uncle (mother's brother)
13 二姨 *èryí* second aunt (mother's sister)
14 三叔 *sānshū* third uncle (father's younger brother)

The children of 伯伯 and 叔叔 share your surname and are called 堂 cousins, 15
such as 堂哥 (older male cousin) or 堂妹 (younger female cousin); all the others are 表 cousins, such as 表姐 or 表弟. Add in male or female, older or younger, and the one word "cousin" turns into eight different words.

Why are Chinese terms of address so complicated? One reason is that Chi- 16
nese families used to be large, with several generations often living together, and everyone's position in the family mattered. A single term carries a lot of information: father's side or mother's side, male or female, older or younger than you. If there are several relatives of the same kind, numbers can be added too, as in 大舅 (eldest uncle on the mother's side), 二姨 (second aunt on the mother's side) or 三叔 (third uncle on the father's side). Today many young people have no brothers or sisters, so their children have fewer and fewer occasions to use these terms.

怎么叫陌生人†

17 有意思的是，这些亲戚‡称呼§也常常用在不认识的人身上。小孩子见到爸爸妈妈的朋友，要叫“叔叔”、“阿姨”；见到老人，要叫“爷爷”、“奶奶”。年轻人之间也常用“哥”和“姐”；在饭馆或者商店里，你可能会听到服务员叫客人“大哥”、“姐”，或者“帅哥”、“美女”。

18 对出租车司机、修东西的工人，人们一般叫“师傅¶”。这个词本来的意思是教手艺*的老师，现在用来表示尊重#。不过，叫人的时候也要小心。如果你叫一位三十岁的女士“阿姨”，她可能会不高兴，因为这听起来好像她已经很老了；叫“姐”或者“美女”就安全多了。

† 陌生人 *mòshēngrén* stranger
‡ 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
§ 称呼 *chēnghu* form of address
¶ 师傅 *shīfu* master (polite address for workers)
* 手艺 *shǒuyì* craft, trade
\# 尊重 *zūnzhòng* respect

Addressing Strangers

Interestingly, these family terms are often used for strangers too. When small children meet their parents' friends they call them 叔叔 and 阿姨 ("uncle", "auntie"), and they call elderly people 爷爷 and 奶奶 ("grandpa", "grandma"). Young people often use 哥 ("big brother") and 姐 ("big sister") among themselves; in restaurants or shops you may hear waiters call customers 大哥 and 姐, or 帅哥 ("handsome") and 美女 ("beautiful"). 17

Taxi drivers and repairmen are generally addressed as 师傅 ("master"). The word originally meant a teacher of a craft; now it is used as a sign of respect. You have to be careful when addressing people, though. If you call a thirty-year-old woman 阿姨, she may be displeased, because it sounds as if she's already old; calling her 姐 or 美女 is much safer. 18

汤姆[1]的年夜饭[2]

19 汤姆是一个在上海[3]工作的英国人。去年春节，他的女朋友小林[4]带他回老家过年，第一次见她的家人。在火车上，小林给他上了一节课："我妈妈有两个哥哥，你要叫大舅[5]、二舅[6]；我爸爸有一个妹妹，你叫她姑姑[7]，她丈夫是姑父[8]……"汤姆认真地记在手机上，可是越记越糊涂[9]。

20 吃年夜饭的时候，一张大桌子坐满了人。一个中年男人给汤姆倒酒，汤姆马上站起来，很有礼貌[10]地说："谢谢叔叔！"大家一下子[11]都笑了。小林小声告诉他："这是我大舅，是我妈妈的哥哥，不是叔叔！"大舅一点儿也不生气，笑着说："没关系，外国朋友能叫叔叔，已经很不错了！"

1 汤姆 *Tāngmǔ* Tom
2 年夜饭 *niányèfàn* New Year's Eve dinner
3 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
4 小林 *Xiǎo Lín* Xiao Lin ("little Lin")
5 大舅 *dàjiù* eldest uncle (mother's brother)
6 二舅 *èrjiù* second uncle (mother's brother)
7 姑姑 *gūgu* aunt (father's sister)
8 姑父 *gūfu* uncle (husband of father's sister)
9 糊涂 *hútu* confused
10 礼貌 *lǐmào* polite, politeness
11 一下子 *yīxiàzi* all at once

Tom's New Year's Eve Dinner

Tom is a British man who works in Shanghai. Last Spring Festival, his girl- 19
friend Xiao Lin took him to her hometown for the New Year, to meet her family for the first time. On the train, Xiao Lin gave him a lesson: "My mum has two older brothers; you call them 大舅 and 二舅. My dad has a younger sister — you call her 姑姑, and her husband is 姑父..." Tom carefully noted it all on his phone, but the more he wrote, the more confused he became.

At the New Year's Eve dinner, a big table was crowded with people. A 20
middle-aged man poured Tom a drink, and Tom immediately stood up and said very politely: "Thank you, 叔叔!" Everyone burst out laughing. Xiao Lin whispered to him: "That's my 大舅, my mum's older brother — not 叔叔!" The uncle wasn't offended in the least. He laughed and said: "Never mind — a foreign friend who can say 叔叔 is already doing very well!"

21 那天晚上，汤姆[1]又叫错了好几次，但是每一次大家都很热情地帮他改。到了十二点，他终于能准确地叫出每个人了。小林[2]的外婆[3]拉着他的手说："明年再来，就是一家人[4]了！"汤姆后来说，这是他学汉语以来上得最有意思的一课。

结语

22 名字和称呼[5]看起来只是小事，其实能告诉我们很多关于中国文化的东西。父母选的每一个字，都有他们对孩子的希望；每一个亲戚[6]称呼，都说明了家庭在中国人心里的位置。如果你去中国朋友家做客，不妨[7]先问一下应该怎么叫他们的家人。就算[8]叫错了也没关系，大家看到你的用心[9]，一定会很高兴。

1 汤姆 *Tāngmǔ* Tom
2 小林 *Xiǎo Lín* Xiao Lin ("little Lin")
3 外婆 *wàipó* grandmother (mother's mother)
4 一家人 *yījiārén* one family
5 称呼 *chēnghu* form of address
6 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
7 不妨 *bùfáng* might as well
8 就算 *jiùsuàn* even if
9 用心 *yòngxīn* effort, care

That evening Tom got people's titles wrong several more times, but each time everyone warmly helped him correct himself. By midnight, he could finally address every person correctly. Xiao Lin's grandmother took his hand and said: "Come again next year — then you'll be one of the family!" Tom said afterwards that it was the most enjoyable Chinese lesson he'd had since he started learning. 21

In Closing

Names and forms of address may look like small matters, but they actually tell us a lot about Chinese culture. Every character parents choose carries their hopes for their child, and every family term shows the place the family holds in Chinese hearts. If you visit a Chinese friend's home, you might as well ask first how you should address their family. Even if you get it wrong it doesn't matter — when people see the effort you're making, they're sure to be pleased. 22